pluralist religious philosophy in the process of instrumentalising it as a political ideology.

The way in which history and cultural memory informs contemporary attitudes varies from family to family. My mother's prosperous Nair family in Palakkad, for instance, lived in mortal terror of imminent attack by Tipu Sultan and lost most of its wealth in a foolish attempt to protect it from him by burying their treasures in an unknown location—they never found them again! But despite the stories that have been wryly and ruefully told and retold and passed down the generations over the two centuries since, my family and I never extended our dislike of Tipu and his marauders to a rejection of 'Muslims' as a whole, and certainly not to any Muslims of today. While we have no illusions about past attacks on temples by Muslim raiders, we did not bring up our children to use the past to justify bigotry in the present. One can appreciate history and leave it where it belongs.

Indians today have to find real answers to the dilemmas of running a plural nation. Nationalists often define their nation in terms of a cohesive group of people, held together by a common enemy. The common enemy of Indians is an internal one, but not the one identified by the Hindutva fanatics and their ilk. The common enemy lies in the forces of sectarian division that would, if unchecked, tear the country apart—or transform it into something that most self-respecting Hindus would refuse to recognise.

In many ways, the fundamental conflict of our times is the clash between, no, not civilisations, but doctrines—religious and ethnic fundamentalism on the one hand, secular consumerist capitalism on the other. The clash is taking place amidst a paradox. Thanks to globalisation, the world has been coming together into a single international market, just as it is simultaneously being torn apart by civil war, terrorism and the breakup of nations. Today there is a backlash, or more accurately two kinds of backlash: one a widely-noted current of economic anti-globalisation, as the 'losers' rebel against the elites who have been exporting their jobs to faraway lands; and the other what one can call cultural anti-globalisation, whose proponents seek the comforts of traditional identity. In many places in the West the two backlashes